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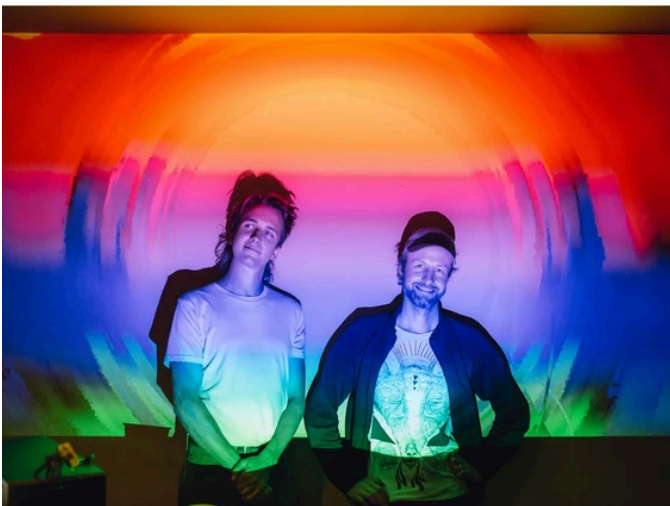
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Wreck City Residency explores 'how we live' with interactive exhibits throughout the city

By [Eric Volmers](#)

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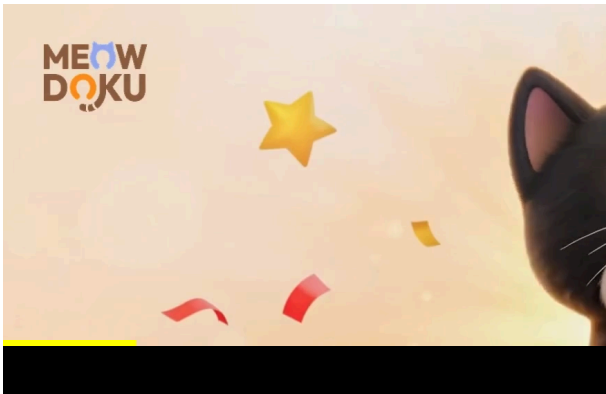
Craig Fahner and Matthew Waddell are artists involved in Wreck City. Courtesy, Diane + Mike Photography. PHOTO BY COURTESY, DIANE + MIKE PHOTOGRAPHY.

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In Craig Fahner and Matthew Waddell's Deep Solutions, visitors can experience their own personal "digital hell" partially populated by people they have unfriended on Facebook.

Well, sort of.



These discarded "friends" take on ominous forms; greyish, doughy figures that wander like ghosts through a virtual-reality world that becomes increasingly chaotic as the experience continues. Their names hover above their heads.

It's an unsettling place, albeit undeniably intriguing. Using virtual-reality technology, participants descend into a space constructed through metadata from their Facebook page, which is voluntarily surrendered by users at the beginning of the process. It starts out rather benign.



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Backed by soothing music, visitors are placed via virtual reality into street views of familiar spots they have checked into while on Facebook. Ads that have appeared on their page eventually start to show up. Before long, users descend into much more sinister surroundings full of strange dating ads, alarmingly muscled body-builders, flashes of weird conspiracy theories and, perhaps most disturbingly, those strange-looking creatures that have taken on the names of people you have unfriended. It's a wild ride from the familiar to the downright unsettling.



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“This is the first person I defriended on Facebook,” Waddell explains, when showcasing his own virtual-reality space for Postmedia earlier this week. “We are starting to descend now into slightly

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stranger bits of the Internet. I think this whole project is about being informative and awakening people to some things. But it's also just exploring the vastness of internet and all the weird things that go on there."

A case in point: One room over is a computer where participants are allowed to browse the so-called deep or dark web; that wild, paranoid and undocumented underworld of the Internet that users can only access anonymously using an encryption tool called Tor. This is where various conspiracy chat sites can be found — both from the far-left and the far-right — and where people often purchase drugs, guns and passports or worse. Fahner and Waddell have wrapped the room in material to block all electro-magnetic radiation.

As a result, it fittingly feels like being locked inside a giant, tinfoil hat.

Deep Solutions is one of dozens of pieces that make up Wreck City Residency, a public exhibition of experimental art set up in "alternative spaces" throughout Calgary. Waddell and Fahner, for instance, have set up shop in what is

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called Radio City, an abandoned recording studio in the Beltline that now houses six temporary exhibits that will be on display until Aug. 12.

Fahner is a Calgary-based artist and musician who used to teach media arts at the Alberta College of Art and Design.

Waddell is a digital artist whose work often explores human interaction with technology. For all the visceral fun of Deep Solutions, its two creators say there is a cautionary-tale element to the exhibit as well.

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“Every part of this is addressing elements of the Internet and the things that we are sharing and maybe don’t realize that we’re sharing,” Waddell says. “We hope that people walk away with a slight awakening

of the extent to which their information is being used and how it is being used to manipulate them to ways that they are not aware of.”

As with most projects of the Wreck City Residency, the focus of Deep Solutions is hands-on participation.

It all began in 2013 when more than 100 artists took over a block of houses in Sunnyside that were earmarked for destruction by a Calgary developer. Over the 10 days, more than 10,000 spectators checked out various projects in the doomed houses.

For the first time, the residency has expanded to four locations. Radio City is at 812A 16 Ave. S.W., House City is at 2240 33rd Ave. S.W., Office City is at 706 7th Ave. S.W. and Old City is at 908 17th Ave. S.W. Throughout the four “cities”, exhibits have been set up in “two houses, an old recording studio, an empty restaurant, a pre-renovation kitchen, a between-functions frame shop, a closed coffee shop, and an office space scheduled for conversion to residential,” says Caitlin Brown, one of Wreck City’s curators.

While the art is varied, there is a broad,
common theme that links them all
together, she says

"There is some sort of thread of how are
we living, how have we lived, how do we
want to live," says Brown.

Wreck City Residency runs until Aug. 12.
Admission is free. Visit wreckcity.ca.



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